

For Cash-Strapped Start-Ups, Open Source Technology is a Boon

Open source technology is not just about an economical solution but also about freedom, flexibility and a lot more. Sparsha Learning Technologies is making it big in the education space, courtesy open source technology. **Diksha P Gupta** from **Open Source For You** spoke to **Debabrata Bagchi, founder, Sparsha**, about how open source software proved to be a boon for this venture.



Debabrata Bagchi, founder, Sparsha Learning Technologies

A successful start-up is all about having a great idea and backing that with the right technology. Sparsha Learning Technologies is one of the finest examples of an idea being transformed into reality with open source software.

Sparsha Learning Technologies is a technology start-up headquartered at IIT, Kharagpur, and has an extended R&D centre at PESIT CORI (Crucible of Research and Innovation), Bengaluru. Sparsha provides technology solutions to create active learning content and integrate it in existing learning solutions. Talking about his start-up, Debabrata Bagchi, founder, Sparsha Learning Technologies, says, "The instructional methodologies of Sparsha Learning Technologies are based on a central philosophy of 'learning-by-doing'. Sparsha designs products for the engineering curriculum using simulation-based learning, which combines cutting-

edge technology with the social aspect of human interaction to create significantly more interesting and engaging learning experiences. We have two products built using open source technology: Electronics Virtual Labs - DoCircuits (www.docircuits.com) and Programming Virtual Labs - Coderipe (www.coderipe.com)."

For both these products, the base platforms and technologies used are open source. Bagchi adds, "DoCircuits and Coderipe are cloud-based products and are based on the LAMP architecture, components of which are entirely open source."

The team at Sparsha is very clear about why it chose open source technologies. Bagchi explains, "Today, open source technologies have matured well enough to be used in production environments. They are more cost effective and, most importantly, the licensing models are open and flexible. For a start-up with limited capital and a fast runway, using open source platforms makes more sense than proprietary solutions."

Sparsha has made complete use of open source technologies and is trying to promote OSS in sectors like higher education, online learning, e-learning, publishing and the hobbyist market. Within these industries, the company deals with engineering colleges, textbook publishers, test and measurement companies, training companies, MOOC publishers, etc.

For all those who believe that cost is the main factor behind start-ups like Sparsha choosing open source technology, here's a disclaimer from Bagchi. He says, "With open source technologies, one gets the convenience of easier on-premise deployments. Also, since there are no licensing restrictions involved, life gets a whole lot easier. Of course, affordability is the cherry on the cake and leads to better pricing of the end products for our customers."

If you are wondering about the challenges involved in the process, Bagchi confidently shares that there were none. He explains, "I have a great comfort level with open source technology. I know, for sure, that I have the controls in my hands. And also, if I am stuck somewhere, community support is something I can bank upon. Popular open source projects have a vibrant community around them. And there is a lot of help available from these communities for users struggling with issues."

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